



QS World University Rankings by Subject – New Zealand universities results

An offshoot of the QS World University Rankings

The Quacquarelli Symonds (QS) World University Subject Rankings are an offshoot of the main QS World University Rankings. These rankings present results at both the broader faculty level and at the more detailed subject level.

The latest edition of the QS subject rankings was published in March 2026. The results can be found at <https://www.topuniversities.com>.

QS rank universities across 55 subject areas

The 2026 QS subject rankings used up to five component measures to generate university rankings in five broad faculty areas and 55 narrow subject areas. QS publishes the rankings of up to the top 850 universities in broader subjects (such as Computer Science & Information Systems) but publishes the rankings of a smaller number of universities in more specialised subject areas (such as Veterinary Science where the top 100 universities are listed) where fewer universities meet the thresholds for inclusion.

The components used to rank institutions include: a survey of academics, a survey of employers, the average number of citations per publication (excluding self-citations), the calculation of an H-index¹ and an International Research Network (IRN) metric.

The weighting applied to each of these components to generate a final ranking varies depending on the subject area. Some subjects (such as Modern Languages) do not use the citations to generate a final ranking. The reason for this variation in weighting is that subjects with a focus on publishing research in journals are more suited to citations analysis.

Rankings attract some criticism

The approach used by QS to generate rankings has been questioned in the academic literature. Among the most significant criticism is the reliance by QS on academic and employer surveys to measure performance. It is argued this represents a measure of perception rather than actual

performance. This is likely to bias the ranking towards universities in the US and the UK. In addition, it is argued that the weightings of the individual components used to generate the final rankings are subjective.

The 2026 results see Veterinary Science and Sports-related Subjects at the top

Table 1 presents the rankings for New Zealand universities in the 2026 QS World University Rankings by Subject.

The key points from the 2026 results are below. All the 2026 results for the New Zealand universities are in Table 1 and Table 2.

Faculty level

- In 2026 there were 28 instances where New Zealand universities were ranked by QS across 5 faculty areas. This compares with 25 in 2025.
- There were 10 instances where New Zealand universities achieved a top 200 ranking at faculty level. This compares to seven in the 2025 edition.
- Seven of the eight New Zealand universities appeared in at least one faculty area ranked by QS.
- The University of Auckland received the highest ranking of a New Zealand university in Arts and Humanities (47) and Social Sciences and Management (58).

Subject level

- In 2026 there were 189 instances where New Zealand universities were ranked by QS across 51 subject level areas. This compares with 191 across 50 subject areas in 2025.
- All eight New Zealand universities had at least one subject ranked by QS. Six of eight universities had at least one subject that was ranked in the top 50.
- Massey University received the highest ranking of a New Zealand university (14) in Veterinary Science followed by the University of Otago in Sports-Related Subjects (22).

¹ The H-index is based on the set of a university department's most cited journal papers and the number of citations that they have received in other publications. It is an attempt to measure both the impact and productivity of published journal articles.

Table 1 Results of the 2026 QS World University Rankings by Subject for New Zealand universities at faculty level.

Faculty	Auckland	Canterbury	Otago	VUW	Massey	Waikato	AUT	Lincoln
Arts & Humanities	47	284	191	102	237	401-450	373	
Engineering & Technology	99	279	451-500	401-450	451-500		451-500	
Life Sciences & Medicine	81		115		301			
Natural Sciences	132	341	326	323	501-500			
Social Sciences & Management	58	246	199	173	283	287	292	

Note: VUW = Victoria University of Wellington and AUT = Auckland University of Technology.

Source: <https://www.topuniversities.com>

Table 2: 2026 QS World University Rankings by Subject for New Zealand universities at subject level

Faculty	Subject	Auckland	Canterbury	Otago	VUW	Massey	Waikato	AUT	Lincoln
Arts & Humanities	Archaeology	28		51-100					
	Architecture / Built Environment	101-150				101-150		201-260	
	Art & Design	101-150				101-150		201-230	
	Classics & Ancient History			51-150					
	English Language & Literature	50	251-300	151-200	90	201-250	251-300		
	History	101-150		201-250	151-200				
	Linguistics	49	61	301-350	73		251-300		
	Modern Languages	101-150	301-350		201-250				
	Performing Arts	101-150							
	Philosophy	101-150		51-100	101-150		201-225		
Engineering & Technology	Theology, Divinity & Religious Studies	101-150		51-100					
	Computer Science & Information Systems	93	401-450	451-500	251-300	601-650	451-500	401-450	
	Data Science and Artificial Intelligence	51-100							
	Engineering - Chemical	151-200	301-350						
	Engineering – Civil & Structural	48	51-100						
	Engineering – Electrical & Electronic	131	301-350		451-500			451-500	
	Engineering – Mechanical, Aeronautical & Manufacturing	105	251-300					451-500	
Life Sciences & Medicine	Agriculture & Forestry		151-200	151-200		49	351-400		82
	Anatomy & Physiology	49		36				101-200	
	Biological Sciences	169	601-650	201-250	601-650	351-400			
	Dentistry			50					
	Medicine	120	701-850	157	601-650	601-650		651-700	
	Nursing	51-100		101-150		151-225		151-225	
	Pharmacy & Pharmacology	85		101-150					
	Psychology	28	251-300	151-200	101-150	251-300	251-300		
	Veterinary Science					14			
Natural Sciences	Chemistry	133	451-500	351-400	551-600	601-700			
	Earth & Marine Sciences	101-150	151-200	201-275	101-150				
	Environmental Sciences	151-200	251-300	351-400	351-400	351-400			
	Geography	51-100	49	101-150	101-150	151-200	201-250		
	Geology	151-200	151-200		151-200				
	Geophysics	101-150	151-200		151-200				
	Materials Science	151-200							
	Mathematics	80	451-500		251-300	501-600			
	Physics & Astronomy	201-250	401-450	401-450	401-450				
	Accounting & Finance	60	251-300	201-250	151-200	151-200	201-250	201-250	
Social Sciences & Management	Anthropology	51-100		101-200	101-200				
	Business & Management Studies	112	301-350	301-350	301-350	351-400	301-350	251-300	
	Communication & Media Studies	101-150			201-250	101-150		251-275	
	Development Studies	101-150				51-100			
	Economics & Econometrics	123	351-400	251-300	301-350	251-300	301-350	401-450	351-400
	Education	29	251-300	201-250	201-250	301-350	201-250	351-400	
	Hospitality & Leisure Management	51-100	51-100	50	51-100		151-175	50	151-175
	Law	65	151-200	151-200	91		251-300		
	Library & Information Management				43				
	Marketing	51-100							
	Politics & International Studies	151-200	201-250	251-300	101-150				
	Social Policy & Administration	101-150							
	Sociology	101-150	251-300	201-250	151-200	301-375	251-300		
	Sports-related Subjects	33		22		101-150	101-150	23	
	Statistics & Operational Research	101-150							

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Source: <https://www.topuniversities.com>